

PORTFOLIO STRATEGY

Ideal Customer Profile

Who this site is built to win — and who it carries along

For: Micah Hoang

Use: Reference for every build, curation, and copy decision. When a choice feels unclear, return here and ask: does this serve the primary ICP?

Companion to: portfolio-framework.md (v0.5) and portfolio-copy-v2.md (v1.1)

00 — How to read this

This is not a list of everyone who might see the site. It's a single primary persona, built in detail, plus two secondary profiles the same site should satisfy without extra work. The premise — confirmed in your framework and reinforced by every answer you gave — is that **work built to win the hardest audience clears the bar for the easier ones**. The reverse is never true. So we optimize for the hardest reader and let the rest benefit.

The portfolio has one reader. Everyone else is a beneficiary of designing for that reader well.

01 — The primary ICP

PERSONA

“The Design Lead.” A senior brand / design lead at an in-house high-craft team — Apple Identity, Anthropic Brand, or Google. The person who opens your link first, because you sent it to them directly.

Role	Senior brand or design lead. Hires for the team, sets the craft bar, owns the “would I want them in the room” call.
Seniority	8–15 years. Has shipped identity systems at scale. Is not impressed by polish — swims in it daily.
How they arrive	Via a link you sent directly (DM or email). Warm enough to open, skeptical by default. They have seen hundreds of junior portfolios and most disappoint.

Emotional state	Mild skepticism with a flicker of hope. Sub-text: “another early-career designer emailed me — is this one different?” The site must disqualify that reflex within seconds.
Time budget	10–20 seconds on the homepage to decide whether to continue. If they continue, 3–5 minutes total. They are scanning, not reading.
Fluency	Total. They read craft, type, and credit instantly. No keyword, resume cue, or “available” badge moves them. Evidence moves them.
Downstream	If they pass you on, the next viewers are also designers judging craft — never a recruiter funnel. The whole loop is a craft audience.

What they are actually scanning for

Three questions, in order. The site has to answer all three, fast:

1. **Can this person actually do the work?** (Craft bar — is the output real and at level?)
2. **Did they really do what they claim?** (Attribution — what was theirs vs. the team's?)
3. **Would I want them in the room?** (Taste, judgment, point of view, ease of collaboration.)

Their three reasons to pass — ranked by your own read

You ranked these yourself. This is the order the site has to defend against:

1. **“I can’t tell what they specifically did.”** The attribution problem. Most acute on your strongest credential (AirPods, a 40-person effort) and least acute on your solo work.
2. **“This reads as a generalist who’ll need narrowing.”** The focus problem. The flip side of the range you love. See Section 02 — this is the central tension.
3. **“The work isn’t at the craft bar yet.”** Mitigated by curation: lead with the work that clears it, cut everything that doesn’t.
4. **“Polished but I can’t see how they think.”** Lowest risk for you — your case study structure already foregrounds thinking. Don’t over-correct into process-dumping.

02 — The central tension (read this twice)

Your two strongest answers contradict each other on the surface. You want the lead to remember “*range across mediums*” — but you also ranked “*reads as generalist / needs narrowing*” as the #2 reason they pass. Those are the same trait seen from two sides.

Range is your favorite thing about your work and the lead’s second-biggest reason to pass.

This is not a contradiction to resolve away. It is *the* problem the ICP is built around. The resolution is already latent in your framework’s smartest line — “range revealed through work, not declared” — but it needs sharpening:

Range only reads as strength when it’s visibly held together by one mind with a point of view. A generalist has range and no center. A systems designer has range *because of* a center. The lead’s fear isn’t that you can do many things — it’s that you can do many things *interchangeably and adequately*, which means a year of narrowing. The site must prove the range is a **consequence**, not a menu.

The fix: change what you want remembered

If they remember...

“range” → you LOSE. That’s the generalist read.

What to engineer

“that brand designer who thinks in systems — and the range is the proof.”

Range as **evidence** of a systems mind, never as the headline. The discipline line you’ve already locked does this correctly: “*Brand designer with a systems mind. Strategy, visual identity, motion.*” Hold that line. Resist every temptation to let the homepage say or imply “multi-disciplinary.”

03 — What the ICP demands of the site

Concrete implications, each traceable to a specific thing the Design Lead is doing or fearing.

a. Credential opens; proof closes

AirPods is your **credential project** — it earns the lead’s attention via the Apple name. Gaia is your **proof project** — you alone carried brand → product → shipped app, which is the cleanest answer to the #1 pass-reason (attribution). These do different jobs. Counterintuitively, leaning too hard on Apple can *increase* attribution suspicion (“you were one of forty”), while the work you may undervalue — a card deck, a self-built app — is your most unambiguous proof that you personally own a system end to end.

- Keep the locked homepage order (AirPods → S&S → Gaia) for the attention argument.
- But make sure Gaia’s case study does the heaviest attribution lifting — it’s the page that converts skepticism into belief. Give it your best end-to-end “*I did all of this, alone*” evidence.
- On AirPods, your hero-lockup-first framing is exactly right: it isolates one unambiguous personal credit before the team context. Protect that structure.

b. The first screen must kill the “another student” reflex

Because you send the link, the lead arrives with a quiet prior: *most cold portfolios are mediocre*. The hero has seconds to break that prior. The Apple credential in the first viewport is the fastest break — not as a brag, but as a frame-reset. Everything below is read in its light.

- Hero must signal craft, not announce availability. The work — or one unmistakable signal of it — does the talking.
- No tagline, no “I design brands that...” sentence (you’ve already locked this — good). The discipline line plus the first project carry it.

c. New-grad question: don’t perform seniority, don’t apologize for it

You said you were unsure how to play this. Here’s the read for *this* viewer: a new grad straining to sound like a ten-year veteran is the most common tell and the fastest disqualifier. Your advantage is an unusual asymmetry — **early-career energy, senior-grade evidence**. You have an Apple launch credit, 20,000 decks in REI, and a shipped iOS app. That body of work *is* the seniority claim; you don’t need to make it in words.

- Let curiosity, velocity, and AI-nativeness read as early-career strengths, not liabilities.
- Keep the voice grounded and precise (your locked tone). Never reach for gravitas the copy hasn’t earned.
- ArtCenter / new-grad status stays on /info under Education — never on the homepage, never in project metadata. The work sets the level before any age signal appears.

d. Everything is read by a fluent eye

Downstream viewers are designers, not recruiters. This frees the site to be quiet and punishes anything that looks like it’s trying:

- No keyword stuffing, no resume optimization, no SEO-bait copy.
- The site-as-a-project ambition is a double edge. Done right, it’s proof of craft. Done slightly over, it reads as a student trying too hard and the site out-shines the work. When unsure, dial the site DOWN and the work UP.
- Custom interactions earn their place only if they signal considered judgment — never as a pattern showcase. (Your motion hierarchy already enforces this.)

04 — Secondary & tertiary audiences

Same site, no extra work — these are satisfied as a byproduct of winning the primary ICP. Listed so you know what each notices, and so you never compromise the primary read to chase them.

PRIMARY The Design Lead — in-house high craft (Apple / Anthropic / Google)

Covered above. Wins on: craft bar, attribution clarity, systems-mind point of view.

SECONDARY The Studio Creative Director (Koto, Mouthwash, Some Days, New Co.)

Why secondary	A studio CD clears a bar set for an Apple lead. Same craft fluency, slightly different priority.
What they add	They care most about taste, editorial sensibility, and clean categorical fit — “can I drop this person in the brand-designer box without hesitation, while noticing the range?”
What serves them	Simon & Schuster, Karuna, Weaponized Innocence (editorial + craft). The Fonts in Use recognition reads loudest here.
Risk to avoid	Don’t let the AI / product / tech signals crowd out the editorial-craft proof. The studio reader needs to see the typographic hand.

TERTIARY The Funded-Startup Founder / Head of Design

Why tertiary	Lowest craft bar of the three, highest velocity bar. Easily satisfied once the primary is met.
What they add	They scan for shipping velocity and AI fluency within ~60 seconds — “will this person make real things, fast?”
What serves them	Gaia (AI-native build), National Park Playing Cards (shipped, real market), and the site itself being AI-built as a second proof.
Risk to avoid	Don’t over-index on “move fast” signals at the expense of craft — that trade reads as a downgrade to the primary ICP.

The quiet fourth reader

A fellow designer who already likes the work and goes deep — peer, friend, someone who forwarded your link. They reward exploration. This is who the /index alphabetical density and the WorldGrid 3D gallery are for. Never let this reader’s payoff leak onto the homepage, where it would undercut restraint for the primary ICP. It’s a reward for going deep, not a front door. (Your framework already nails this — keep it.)

05 — The one-page reference

Pin this. When a build decision feels unclear, check it against these.

THE READER

A skeptical-but-hopeful senior design lead at an in-house high-craft team, opening a link you sent, with 15 seconds and a fluent eye.

THEIR THREE QUESTIONS

Can they do the work? / Did they really do it? / Would I want them in the room?

THE ONE THING TO BE REMEMBERED

“A brand designer who thinks in systems — and the range is the proof.”

THE TEST FOR EVERY DECISION

4. Does this make craft, attribution, or point-of-view clearer? → Keep.
5. Does it make the range read as a menu rather than a consequence? → Cut.
6. Is the site out-shining the work? → Dial the site down.
7. Is it performing seniority the work hasn't earned? → Cut.

Open question worth revisiting: *among Apple Identity, Anthropic, and Google, is one the true bullseye? They share a craft bar but differ in culture — Anthropic and Google reward the AI-native / product signals more openly than Apple Identity, which is the purest brand-craft read. If one becomes the real target, we can sharpen the primary persona one notch further.*